Luke speaks.

Keynotes and conference workshops

From care leaver to care leader.

Seven keynotes with Luke Rodgers BEM, for everyone who works with children in care.



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Luke Rodgers BEM
Founder and CEO, The Care Leaders

Keynotes with Luke Rodgers BEM

Meet Luke

From care leaver to care leader.

"I went into care at 10. At 15 I was living in a B&B, and at 18 I was in a caravan. I gave my first keynote at 19, standing in front of a room of professionals and telling them what care had felt like from the inside. I've been doing it ever since, because it's still one of the fastest ways I know to change how people see children in care.

That's why I set up The Care Leaders: to go from care leaver to care leader, and to help others make the same move. Since then I've led the national engagement on England's new fostering standards, been a Knowledge Equity Fellow at Saïd Business School, Oxford, and been awarded the British Empire Medal."

British Empire Medal
Awarded in 2018.

Knowledge Equity Fellow
Saïd Business School, University of Oxford.

National leadership
Engagement lead on England's new fostering standards.

Spoken at
Community Care Live, the Local Government Association, NAVSH national conferences, and online to audiences in Australia.

45+
keynotes since the start of 2024

30 to 400
people in the room, from team away days to national conferences

4,000+
delegates expected since 2024, from organisers' booking numbers

400
people in the largest single room so far

How every keynote works

Three parts. Every talk.

1

Story

Luke draws on his lived experience to share stories of care.

2

Theory

The evidence behind it.

3

Action

Tools to use the next day.

- 45 to 90 minutes
- In person or online
- Shaped to your audience
- Time for questions

Choose a talk

Seven talks, one spine.

1	Living a Careless Life	For mixed audiences	p6
2	Just Say Yes	For foster carers	p7
3	The Power of the Profile	For social workers	p8
4	Tools for Schools	For schools and colleges	p9
5	Lived Experience Leadership	For senior leaders	p10
6	From Care Leaver to Care Leader	For care-experienced young people	p11
7	Be the First Yes	For employers	p12

Or one built for your audience: tell us who's in the room.



Not sure which fits?

Tell us your audience, we'll recommend one.

1 For mixed audiences **Flagship talk**

Living a Careless Life

By the end, delegates will

- What children in care notice that adults miss
- The moments that build trust, and the ones that break it
- How systems and language can make children feel like a case
- What one adult can change

Staff and leaders make decisions about children in care every day without hearing what it is like from the inside. Language, processes and missed moments can make a child feel like a case, and nobody in the room notices. This is the talk that changes that.

Who it's for
Whole services, conferences, schools and corporate parenting boards

Length
45 to 90 minutes

Format
Keynote or conference workshop, in person or live online



2 For foster carers

Just Say Yes

By the end, delegates will

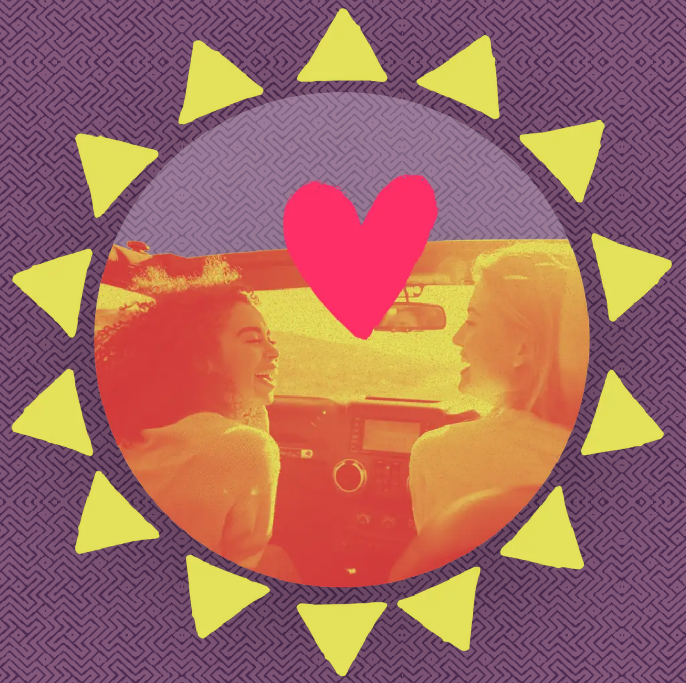
- Understand how profiles shape what carers expect
- Know the basics of trauma, attachment and behaviour as communication
- Respond to hard moments with empathy, not fear
- Leave with simple tools for daily care, and the confidence to say yes

Saying yes to a child often starts with a profile full of risks, behaviours and past moves, and rarely the full story. Then carers are asked to meet needs shaped by trauma and loss without training that explains why. That is not a failure of fostering. It is a gap in how we prepare carers, and this talk bridges it.

Who it's for
Foster carers, kinship carers and the fostering teams who support them

Length
45 to 90 minutes

Format
Keynote or conference workshop, in person or live online



3 For social workers

The Power of the Profile

By the end, delegates will

- Write profiles that inspire belief, not fear
- Reframe behaviour through a trauma-informed lens
- Understand the emotional and ethical weight of telling a child's story
- Feel renewed confidence in advocating for a child

The profile a social worker writes becomes a child's introduction to a school, a carer or a panel. It is often built from inherited case notes and incident logs, so the child is described by what went wrong. When the answer is no, it is the social worker who carries it. This talk is for the practitioner who knows the young person behind the paperwork.

Who it's for
Social workers at every level, team managers, supervising social workers, IROs and students

Length
45 to 90 minutes

Format
Keynote or conference workshop, in person or live online



4 For schools and colleges

Tools for Schools

By the end, delegates will

- Read behaviour as communication and respond in the moment
- Know what attachment and trauma look like in school
- Understand how language and stigma shape a child's school life
- Know where school and social care clash, and what to do about it

For a child in care, school can become another place to feel misunderstood, especially when their past arrives as a behaviour record. Most teacher training doesn't cover trauma or children in care, yet schools are expected to be a critical support. This talk gives staff the understanding and the tools.

Who it's for
Headteachers, designated teachers, teachers and college staff

Length
45 to 90 minutes

Format
Keynote or conference workshop, in person or live online



5 For senior leaders

Lived Experience Leadership

By the end, delegates will

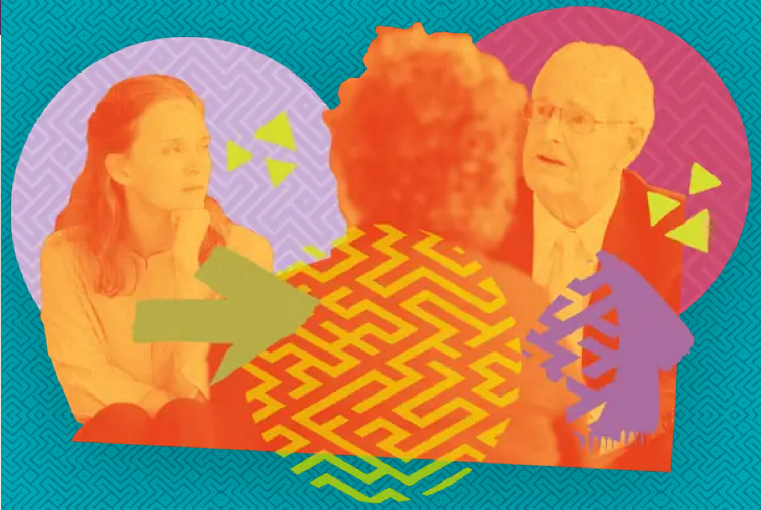
- See the skills that hard experiences can build
- Recognise lived experience as expertise, not only a story
- Reflect that back to the children and young people they work with
- Involve people with lived experience as leaders in their service

We tend to see hard experiences as things that hold people back. This talk reframes them. A child who moves home is learning to adapt; a child who changes school is learning to read people and build relationships. Leaders who see lived experience this way work alongside people with it as leaders, not only for their story.

Who it's for
Senior leaders, leadership teams and anyone who works with children

Length
45 to 90 minutes

Format
Keynote or conference workshop, in person or live online



6 For care-experienced young people

From Care Leaver to Care Leader

By the end, delegates will

- See their care experience as a strength, not a weakness
- Recognise the skills they already have
- Feel more confident about their future
- See themselves as people who can lead change

Care-experienced young people are often described by other people's words: case notes, risk assessments and plans that follow them into school, housing and work. This talk helps them see that what they have lived through has built real skills, and that they can lead because of their experience, not in spite of it.

Who it's for
Care-experienced young people aged 14 and over, children in care councils and care leaver groups

Length
45 to 90 minutes

Format
Keynote or conference workshop, in person or live online



7 For employers

Be the First Yes

By the end, delegates will

- Understand who care leavers are and what support really looks like
- Know how to make recruitment and induction care-aware
- Plan mentoring and onboarding that helps people stay
- Feel confident, not cautious, about being the first yes

Care leavers often start working life without the family networks, references and safety nets most people take for granted. Employers want to do the right thing but worry about getting it wrong. Care leavers aren't asking for special treatment. They are asking for a chance, and this talk shows how to give one.

Who it's for
Employers, HR and early careers teams, hiring managers and social value leads

Length
45 to 90 minutes

Format
Keynote or conference workshop, in person or live online



It doesn't stop at a keynote.

You also get:



1 The workbook

For every delegate, printed or digital, built around the talk.



2 The online course

Keep learning on The Care Leaders Online, at your own pace.



3 The video

The full keynote, recorded, for 12 months.

Every keynote comes with a workbook.

Each of the seven talks has its own workbook, laid out like the talk: the story, the theory behind it, then the tools. Delegates keep one child or young person in mind as they go, so the learning lands on someone they know.



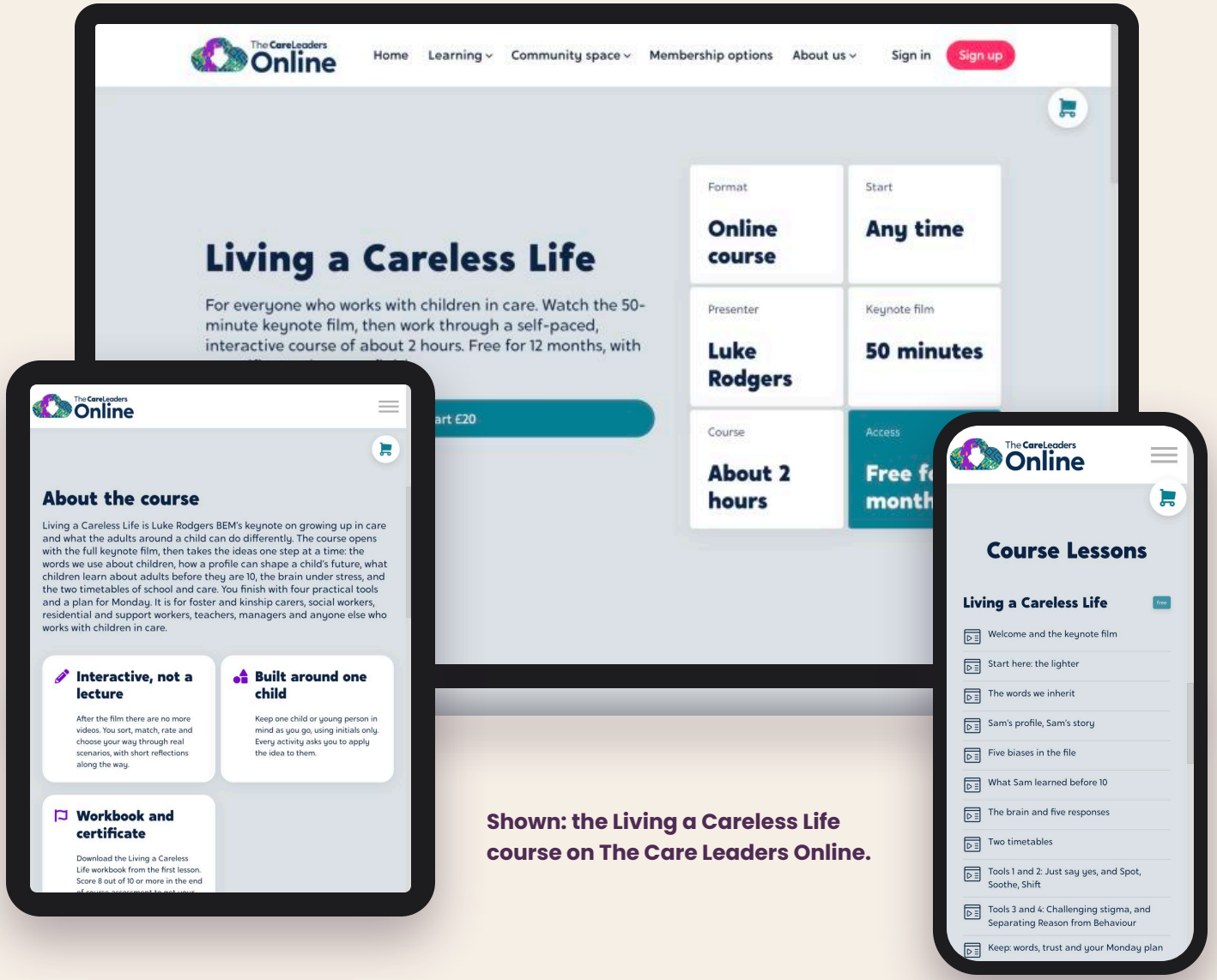
- One for every delegate
- Printed or digital
- Activities for individuals and teams
- Your logo on the cover on request

Keep learning on The Care Leaders Online.

Living a Careless Life comes with its own online course. Delegates scan a QR code on the last slide, get the workbook straight away, then free access to the course for 12 months, on a laptop, tablet or phone.

- Opens with the full 50-minute keynote film
- A self-paced course of about two hours
- Interactive, built around one child
- A certificate when you finish

For the other talks: ask us about online learning for your audience.



Shown: the Living a Careless Life course on The Care Leaders Online.



3 · The video

The full keynote, for 12 months.

Every delegate can watch the keynote again on The Care Leaders Online for 12 months after your event, and share it with colleagues who couldn't be there.

- The full keynote, filmed
- 12 months' access for every delegate
- A link you can put in your follow-up email
- The slides, so you can share them too



What people say

In their words.

Nothing was as transformative as hearing Luke speak about his life.

Dr Janet Rose, Principal, Norland College

I have seen them in action at many conferences and have heard professionals report changes in their own behaviour.

Professor Judy Sebba, Rees Centre, University of Oxford

You demand bravery and humanity in equal measure.

Maggie Atkinson, Former Children's Commissioner for England

Who we work with

Durham County Council · Kent County Council · Kirklees Council · Suffolk County Council · Buckinghamshire Council

NAVSH National Association of Virtual School Heads · NSPCC · The Fostering Network · National Fostering Group · pwc

Luke speaks.

Book Luke for your event.

1 **Tell us about your event**
The date, your audience and whether you're after a keynote, a workshop or both.

2 **Get availability and a fee**
Luke's availability, the fee and the talk we'd recommend. If Luke is free, we hold the date for 14 days.

3 **Confirm by email**
Reply to confirm and send a purchase order if you use them. Our booking terms come with the email.

4 **Before the day**
A 30-minute call to shape the talk around your audience, and a checklist of what Luke needs.

5 **After the day**
A follow-up call if you want one, with delegate feedback where we gathered it.

hello@thecareleaders.com · 0800 233 5597

Scan to tell us about your event. We reply within 3 working days.

iese Awards GOLD Winner 2026 — The Public Sector Transformation Awards

Children & Young People Now Awards 2023 Winner

Gold, Dual Perspective Leadership Award, iESE Public Sector Transformation Awards 2026.
Children & Young People Now Workforce Development Award 2023.

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